

TO FINESSE OR NOT?

South opens with a strong spade hand and the partnership reaches 4♠.

Teaching feature: COUNT YOUR TRICKS FIRST. Declarer has so many sure tricks (typically 10-11 without help) that the contract is already there. A finesse is available in clubs, but it has NO UPSIDE — you don't need the trick — and a real downside if it loses. Don't take a finesse you don't need.

Holdings:

- Spades — AKQJT in South, x or xx in dummy. Solid trump suit.
- Hearts — A in South, small in dummy. One control.
- Diamonds — split honors. Two or three tricks.
- Clubs — A and J on declarer's side, K opposite. The Queen is missing; the finesse is for an overtrick only.

The right line: count to ten. If the contract is cold on top tricks and ruffs, draw trumps and claim — there is nothing to gain from the club finesse and a needless risk in giving up the lead. (East holds long hearts, but in a trump contract that is at most one cashing trick before you ruff — the point is not the heart danger, it's that the finesse simply isn't needed.)

Reference: count winners and losers before deciding any finesse.

<https://www.bridgebum.com/counting.php>